Chapter 12: Fight People Better Than You. Lose.

Erik did live in Terrian for the next two weeks, so he walked into the arena with team Terrian.

He embraced Catria before walking to his team platform.

“Have you asked her yet?” Dillion teased.

“That wouldn’t be proper,” Erik countered. “We haven’t known each other long enough.”

“Who cares about proper?” Dillion countered. “You know your in love. Just ask her to marry you.”

“I want to,” Erik replied. “But she’s not a Cruian girl. Sure, in Cruia, it would be fine, but Terrian is different.”

“She knows what Cruia is,” Dillion pointed out. “You brought her there last week. She loved it. She’s not stuffy and too proper to get offended if you ask her now.”

Erik’s eyebrows furrowed. “What if she says no?”

“She won’t. You know it,” Dillion insisted. “Just do

it. Take the plunge. I asked my girl to marry me just yesterday. She said yes."

"That's great!" Erik exclaimed, but he said no more because York called everyone to attention.

"It is a heavy battle day," York announced. "But before any battles, there is a punishment to administer. We have captured one of the men in the thieving ring. He will be punished now."

The Phyrnian Erik had captured was brought in. He was walking slowly, as if already in pain, but he said nothing.

He had his shirt removed and was taken to the field, where he was tied and beaten with a dozen lashes from a fire whip.

Most of the crowd couldn't watch, but the people from Ramere chanted, "We want blood!"

After the punishment, the man was dragged off the field.

York stood up in front of the crowd again. "It is sad that people must be punished, but if there is no punishment for crime, there is no law, and we must have law to have peace and to get the war to stop. Now, there are many battles today. First, Ramere is attacking Phyrn because of the stolen goods. Second, Phyrn is attacking Cruia to again try to get Xena turned over. Third, Alfir is attacking Murash for a boatload of fish. Fourth, Phyrn is attacking Terrian for the return of Bruis again. Fifth Aschelle is attacking Terrian to have the team captain

captured by them."

Everyone gasped. Battles to capture war mages had been rumored from years before, but had not be legal in the past twenty years. Murmurs ran through the crowd.

York quieted them and announced, "Ramere is now attacking Phyrn because Phyrn obviously stole from them. The stolen goods have been returned, but Ramere insists on repaying fourfold. No one's life is on the line, so fighting past gems dark is not allowed. Three on three."

Catria leaned over to Hrod and whispered, "How is Phyrn going to do three battles, they are down two war mages, and doesn't the captain always have to fight?"

"Yes," Hrod confirmed. "But if the battles are not more than three on three, they have enough, and York can allow the captain not to fight if his gem is dark."

"Do you think they will call off their attack?" Catria asked.

Hrod glanced over with a look that gently crushed her optimism and answered, "No, Phyrn does not call off attacks."

Catria clutched his arm. "Our team fights twice today. I may have to end up taking the field. I became a war mage to heal, not fight."

"But you are a good fighter," Hrod assured her. "If you have to fight, you can hold your own. Keep healing yourself, and you may be the most valuable war mage on

the field."

Her head cocked curiously. "I haven't had to heal myself. I don't know if I can. I may only be able to heal others."

"If your healing only heals in service, remember that you must heal yourself first so you can heal others," Hrod suggested. "Keep your gem full, and we will win."

They then turned their attention to the field, as the battle between Ramere and Phyrn was about to start.

It was a brutal battle, as both sides were strong fighters, but Ramere came out on top.

Catria was glad the captain of Ramere's team didn't have to be punished for losing.

Hrod leaned over to her. "I'm not surprised they lost. They fought Krunth and Bantha, who are new. They are saving their best war mages to fight Cruia and us."

York called for the attack Phyrn verses Cruia. Again the fight was three on three.

"My gem is dark," Slayde called to York. "Do I have to fight this round?"

York thought for a moment before answering, "No. You may heal for the next fight." He called over to Terrian, "Have your healer heal him."

That was an odd request, definitely one Carlin wouldn't have made. Seriously, York wanted Slayde healed so he could fight the team who just healed him.

“Only if he calls off the battle with us,” Rhys countered.

“If Catria refuses, she will be punished,” York insisted. “My commands will be followed.”

Commands… That was an odd word to use. Did York see himself as the king of the arena? Rhys shook his head. No, York more likely saw himself as the god of the arena.

“We refuse, and you can punish me, as her team captain, in her place.”

“Wait!” Catria insisted. “I’ll heal him if I can, but I heal wounds, not fill gems. Slayde’s gem is dark, but I don’t know he’s really that wounded.”

Rhys turned to her and explained in a low enough voice that York couldn’t hear, “It’s better for me to take the punishment and you heal me than to heal Slayde and let him fight us.”

It didn’t matter what he said. York announced, “Katria has agreed. Let the fights continue. Phyrn verses Cruia, two against two.”

Two lesser war mages came to Catria and escorted her over to heal Slayde. Of course, Rhys and Hrod went with her, just in case she needed protection.

As they did, two Phyrnians and two Cruian boys took the field. Phyrn sent Payne and Maeme to fight, and Cruia sent Dillion and Erik.

Hrod leaned over to Catria again. “Phyrn is sending

their toughest besides Slayde. It seems Slayde wants Xena back more than Bruis."

Catria tensed. "Do you think Cruia will win."

Hrod laughed. "I have no doubt. I'm more worried about the repercussions of the fight than the fight itself."

He was definitely right not to worry about the fight. Catria was on the edge of her seat, worried about Erik, but he shielded himself and Dillion so well that neither of their shields went down at all.

Payne and Maeme were both livid when they had to leave the field and hadn't brought down either Dillion or Erik, but Catria was cheering happily.

She went to the Cruian platform and was waiting when Erik and Dillion came up. She threw her arms around Erik and kissed him.

"Wow!" he exclaimed, and he showed her his gem had gone instantly to full.

She looked confused. "I didn't know I could heal that well that quickly."

He winked at her. "Perhaps it's because you love me so much."

She blushed a bright pink, but said nothing back as York called for the next fight, Alfir verses Murash.

The fight was interesting to watch, as Alfir was full of Faeborn, and some had some very unusual abilities. One of their warmages was part grogosh, so he could go invisible even while fighting with his double daggers.

Blind fighting is hard.

Alfir's captain was part high elf, so his reflexes were super fast, even wielding a great sword. The other person they decided to have fight was part wind nymph. His flail was bad enough, but he could also control wind to some extent.

Murash was good, but they were a fishing city and didn't stand a chance against Alfir. Yet, they fought hard. The loss of the boatload of fish was not too hard on them, but they feared magic, so they fought hard against the Faeborn.

Catria returned to her platform during the fight. When it ended, she tensed. Her team was about to go into two fights, one against Phyrn and one against Aschelle. She didn't want to see either Bruis go free or Rhys turned over to Aschelle, so they had to win, but if she had to fight, could she?

She could feel her hands trembling as she reached over and grabbed Hrod's arm. "We're next."

"We are," Hrod agreed. "If you have to fight, stay near me, and fight hard."

Catria could feel her heart racing inside her as York announced, "We'll now fight Phyrn attacking Terrian, four on four."